Digital Bling

From diamond-studded headphones to gold-clad smartphones and jewel-encrusted watches, luxury technology is turning everyday devices into extravagant collector's pieces that marry cutting-edge innovation with the enduring appeal of precious materials

BY **NIDHI SINGAL**

WEALTH HAS ALWAYS found ways to make the utilitarian decadent. Historically, that meant custom-stitched leathers, bespoke automobile finishes, and timepieces crafted from meteoric iron. But as technology tightened its grip on every facet of modern existence, the ultra-wealthy faced a glaring stylistic dilemma: how does one reconcile a trillion-dollar lifestyle with a pocketful of mass-manufactured glass and aluminium?

Then the jewels got involved. Gold began replacing aluminium. Diamonds found their way around earcups. Rubies, emeralds, and sapphires started appearing on screens, cases, and bezels.

While technology belongs to the present, constantly evolving and relentlessly replaced, fine jewellery belongs to a different time, where craftsmanship, provenance, and precious materials acquire meaning across generations. When the two converge, a device designed for obsolescence can become an object of permanence. Its electronics may eventually fall behind, but the gold, diamonds and gemstones endure, precious enough to become part of a legacy.

Statement on the wrist

FOR THOSE WHO favour extravagance with a darker edge, VERTU's Fusion Hamlet Design Diamond Watch makes a striking case for wearable luxury. This limited edition combines the precision of smart technology with the opulence of hand-set precious stones. Over 500 genuine South African diamonds and 4.75 carats of brilliant Burmese rubies lend the timepiece its lavish character, while a 6.925-carat anti-glare sapphire crystal protects the 1.85-inch true colour high-resolution display.

Beneath its jewel-encrusted exterior, the watch houses a high-performance customised chip with Web3 access, a secure digital wallet for cryptocurrency assets and over-the-air software upgrades. Its health monitoring system, driven by artificial intelligence (AI), tracks heart rate, blood oxygen levels, and deep sleep, alongside multi-sport tracking. Forged from premium carbon fibre and paired with a custom FKM strap, the watch is engineered to withstand temperatures ranging from minus 40°C to 225°C.

VERTU FUSION HAMLET DESIGN DIAMOND WATCH
PRICE $4,99,000